

Designing for Emotional Impact

Highlights

- Designing for emotional impact
- Emotional needs
- Conceptual design for emotional aspects
- Metaphors
- Mood boards
- Intermediate emotional impact design
- National parks example
- Emotional impact design production

17.1 INTRODUCTION

17.1.1 You Are Here

We begin each process chapter with a “You are here” picture of the chapter topic in the context of The Wheel, the overall UX design lifecycle template (Fig. 17.1).

17.1.2 Designing for Emotional Impact Is Often Neglected but Can Be a Market Differentiator

In the day-to-day designs for products and systems, particularly enterprise software, business stakeholders focus on supporting the middle (interaction) tier of the needs pyramid and to a lesser extent the bottom (ecological) tier. The top (emotional) tier is often neglected. Designing for emotional needs may not even be mandated in the design brief, but it may end up becoming the differentiator that offers the potential to be a market leader. A product or system that satisfies emotional needs can distinguish good from great products.

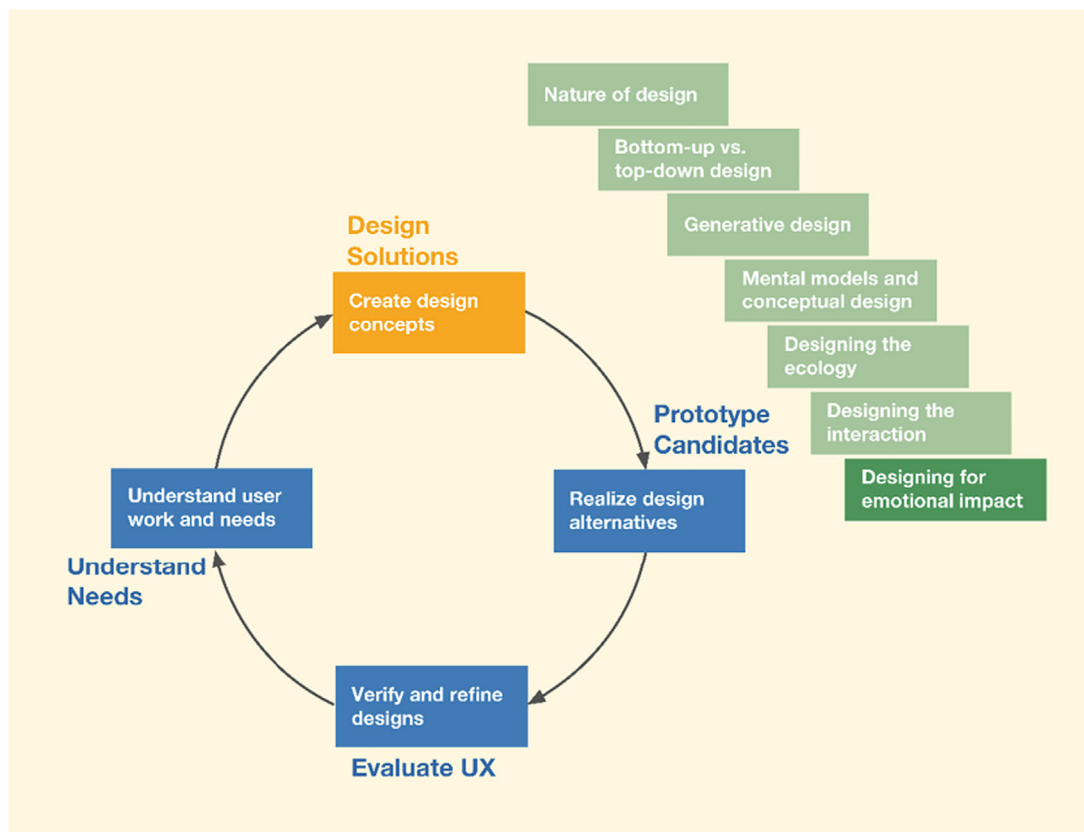


Fig. 17.1

You are here in the chapter describing designing for emotional impact within the design solutions activity in the context of the overall Wheel UX lifecycle.

17.2 EMOTIONAL NEEDS

In [Section 11.2.1](#), we described how emotional needs occupy the top layer of the human needs pyramid. Users want value-sensitive designs that offer user satisfaction, aesthetics, and joy of use. On a deeper level, they need enrichment and cultural satisfaction as they use a product. Users also crave meaningfulness in designs that are endearing and timeless, with the potential for becoming an intimate part of their lives.

17.2.1 Sometimes Users Crave Distinctiveness

For some products, the goal is to elicit an emotional response in users by producing something different and noticeable, to craft an artistic design for the coolest and best piece of art a product can be. Examples include furniture,

jewelry, fashion clothing, and architecture. These domains are full of everyday products that satisfy ecological and interaction needs, but the world adores creations by designers who infuse unique emotional perspectives into their work. Who would not like the cachet of owning custom designer clothing? Or a home designed by Frank Lloyd Wright? Or an original Charles Eames chair?

As another example, take the Mini Cooper automobile. The small boxy look could have ended up being plain and utilitarian, but designers made the boxy look a distinguishing feature. The very idea of the car conjures fun and excitement with its distinctive looks and interior design. The designers use controls and toggle switches that are inspired by airplane cockpits. The location and shape of the central information console follows this concept as well. The result is a fun and adventuresome theme that is consistent with their famous go-cart-like handling. Ask Mini drivers about what their Mini means to them, and they are likely to describe it in emotional terms.

17.3 DESIGNING FOR EMOTIONAL IMPACT TO SATISFY EMOTIONAL NEEDS

Humans have a broad range of feelings that are aroused by what they see, hear, and touch. For example, if the goal of the design is to delight the user, say, for a children's tablet app, a playful visual palette with bold colors combined with the right animations and screen transitions and generous use of audio cues can induce that emotion. On the other hand, if the goal is to communicate stability and reliability, say, for a stock trading application, a more restrained visual style where colors are used only for encoding information can induce an emotion of seriousness, safety, and being productive. For example, you could use green to show gains in the price of a financial instrument and red to show losses. In such systems, the use of audio will also be relegated to task-focused issues, such as communicating error states and notifications.

Designing for emotional impact is perhaps the most difficult kind of design to operationalize and externalize as a process. Unlike the ecological or interaction design efforts, there are no straightforward work activity models that directly inform emotional impact attributes. These must be carefully gleaned and nurtured from the users and the UX research data. Moreover, emotional response targets vary (e.g., in consumer products, responses such as delight and joy are important, whereas in institutional or enterprise products, the goals are more toward reducing boredom in repetitive tasks and engendering satisfaction during task performance).

Fig. 17.2 provides common goals to consider when designing for emotional impact.

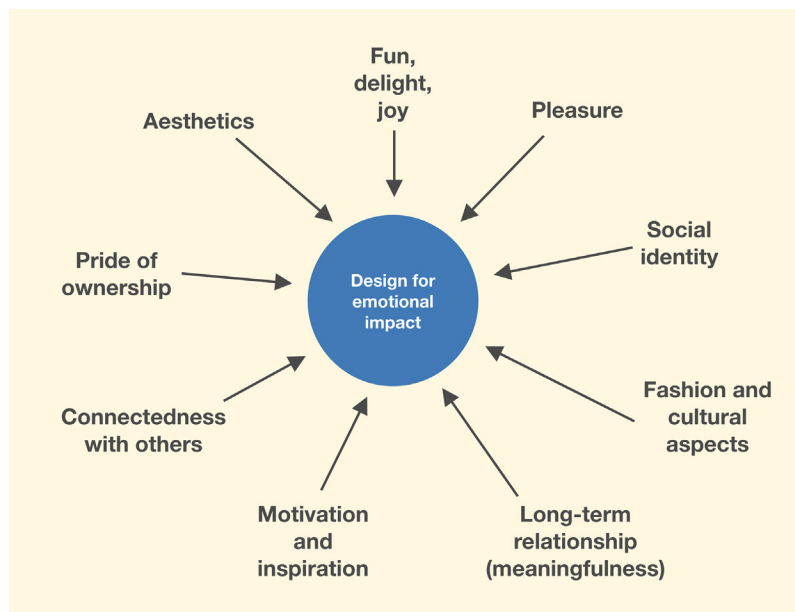


Fig. 17.2
Possible design goals for emotional impact and meaningfulness.

The purpose of the model in [Fig. 17.2](#) is to begin identifying and organizing user needs in terms of design goals. In this model, for each design goal arrow pointing toward the center, we identify the specific kinds of needs for users with respect to this product. For example, for the fashion factor, what is important to users about this product? Is it being avant-garde? Being retro? Being modern? Once this is identified, designers can address ideation, sketching, and critiquing how to achieve each factor specifically in the design.

17.4 CONCEPTUAL DESIGN FOR EMOTIONAL ASPECTS

Conceptual designs for emotional aspects are often more abstract and difficult to articulate. They span concepts for branding, visual or graphic design, sound, motion, and even the tone of language used. It is an abstract theme centered around an idea or a factor.

17.4.1 Metaphors

Metaphors can be used to articulate an emotional conceptual design. An example is seen in advertising in *Backpacker* magazine for the Garmin handheld GPS as a hiking companion. In a metaphor that ties the human value of self-identity with orienteering, Garmin says, “Find yourself, then get back.” It highlights emotional qualities, such as comfort, cozy familiarity, and companionship: “Like an old pair of boots and your favorite fleece, GPSMAP 62ST is the ideal hiking companion.”

17.4.2 Mood Boards: Creating a Conceptual Design for Emotional Aspects

Use ideation to come up with the various themes and metaphors you think are appropriate for the product being designed. For each theme under consideration in the design, create a mood board (a collage of artifacts and images showcasing or illustrating different aspects of a theme). A mood board can include sketches of shapes, color samples, pictures, sounds, typefaces, or any other artifacts. There are no rules on how it should be structured; the goal is for the various combined elements to carry the feeling of the abstract idea being communicated.

Example: Mood Boards for the National Parks Website

Fig. 17.3 contains an example of a mood board based on the theme of vibrant nature. This mood board was constructed for the national parks product

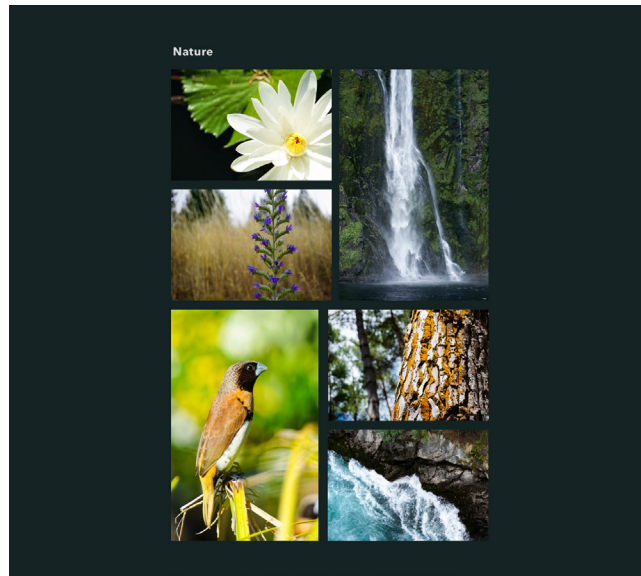


Fig. 17.3

Mood board for the theme of vibrant nature to be used as a concept for the visual design of a national parks website (from Christina Janczak, Product Design Manager, Arista Networks, Inc.).

introduced in [Section 16.7.1](#). This is one of the many themes the design team explored for this exercise. The various pictures and sights depicted in this mood board illustrate the vibrancy and energy of nature, making it attractive for potential park visitors and campers.

Notice the connection of emotional impact in the national parks campground design to Annie's love of nature in her persona (see [Section 16.7.1.2](#)). Her deep emotional attachment to nature means that anything a campground website can do to make an emotional connection will be attractive and engaging for Annie.

17.5 INTERMEDIATE DESIGN FOR EMOTIONAL IMPACT

After a conceptual design is adopted, develop it further by elaborating each sensory channel (e.g., visual, auditory, tactile) through more detailed mood boards, ideation, and sketching.

17.5.1 Define the Visual Language and Vocabulary

Visual design is perhaps the most common channel used in practice for emotional impact. In this case, mood boards give a flavor of the visual language to be used in the system.

We were once tasked by a client in New York City to design an emotional response of boldness and dynamism for a mobile application. We created a visual mood board with images of iconic New York City themes: yellow cabs, metro signs, skyscrapers, and movement (captured via blurry shots of people on the street and in Times Square). This was later developed into specific visual aspects, such as typography, by using the font families found on the city subway signage.

Begin defining your overall visual theme by creating a mood board for each of the themes you think are appropriate for the system being designed. Make sure they include typography and iconography.

The typography styles include font families, how and if they will be different across different devices in the ecology, and how the various styles (e.g., headings, body, callouts, button labels) will look. A team member with a strong graphic design background is an asset for this.

Identify all ideas that will be represented as icons or other images in the design and define the style for iconography. Create sample views of key screens if appropriate to get a sense of how the visual style contributes to the overall concept for the emotional design.

Example: Color Scheme for the National Parks Website

Continuing with the national parks example, note how Fig. 17.4 portrays the color scheme that was derived from the mood board in Fig. 17.3. The designer picked a key image of the mood board and extracted various aspects, such as the green color of the leaf, the white color of a full flower petal, the yellow color of the flower center, and the dark shadow of the water to derive the primary color palette (top left of the image).

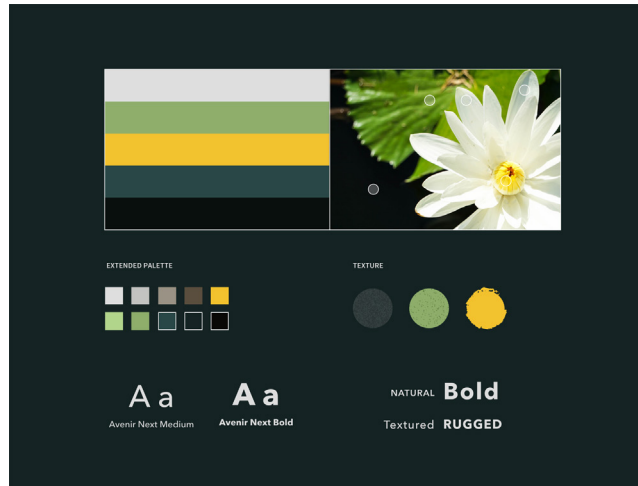


Fig. 17.4

Formulating color palette, typography, and visual language from the vibrant nature themed mood board (from Christina Janczak, Product Design Manager, Arista Networks, Inc.).

Another set of colors was picked from other images in the mood board to create the secondary (extended) palette (center left of the image). The designer also derived textures (center right in the image) from other areas in the mood board (the small circles) that will be used in the design to evoke the theme of vibrant nature.

Example: Iconography for the National Parks Website

Fig. 17.5 displays the iconography the designer created as the next step.

As these designs were critiqued, the issue of texture was brought up as a way to make the visual language more organic. The result was the icons shown in Fig. 17.6.

17.5.2 Define the Motion Styles and Physics of Interaction for Each Design

For each device in the ecology, define the styles and physics for the animations and other transitions to be used. This will include ideas on using animations,



Fig. 17.5
Iconography for the national parks product using the visual themes from the tranquil nature mood board (from Christina Janczak, Product Design Manager, Arista Networks, Inc.).



Fig. 17.6
Applying texture to icons makes them seem more natural (from Christina Janczak, Product Design Manager, Arista Networks, Inc.).

scrolling, and screen transitions as well as descriptions of how the motions will occur. Having people with a motion design background on the team helps. They sketch ideas for these kinds of motion to describe accelerations, timing, and more.

We talked about the use of animation in an iPad iBooks app that simulates physically turning a page in [Section 14.3.6](#). What are the opportunities for using animations in your application? For example, look for places where the

system is performing long operations; a loading animation may help in such areas.

Think of how the physics of the interaction will work. If there are two panes of content, which one is the primary and which is the secondary? Which pane will slide over the other? Will it slide in from the left or the right? Which is more consistent with the way the application widgets are arranged?

17.5.3 Define the tone of the language to be used in the design

Another avenue that designers use for emotional impact is the tone and style of the language. Use of humor and anthropomorphism to imbue a personality in certain domains, such as kids learning, adult gaming, and entertainment, is common. This is captured using samples and textual descriptions of the tone to be achieved on a mood board.

For the overall ecology, what is the tone of the language used in all dialogue with the user (user interface, video, and audio interactions)? Will it be conversational and informal or terse and formal? Will it use humor? Will it have a personality of its own or will it be neutral?

Keep updating the product's design library for language and tone. List words, phrases, and themes that should be avoided and examples of what should be used.

17.5.4 Define the Audio Characteristics To Be Used in the Design

For the design of sounds, develop ideas for appropriate actions that can be augmented by using sounds. The enclosed user space of a kiosk is perfect for gentle surround sound, which will add much to the feeling of immersion. What are the opportunities for providing feedback to the user during interactions? What is the overall theme of the sounds—uplifting and playful or sober and serious?

Begin by identifying themes and use audio samples of music to assemble a palette of sounds corresponding to the different categories of tasks. For example, alerts will have one tone, whereas positive feedback for actions will have another. For the national parks application, the nature mood board can include a variety of nature sounds, and those sounds can then be used to derive the audio vocabulary for the design.

When designing interaction using audio, keep in mind the usage context where sound will be used. Consumer apps, where individual users interact with your system in the comfort of their home, require a different audio

palette than an enterprise application used by a team in an open office context. We once had to design audio alerts for an application that was to be used on a densely packed trading floor. After the team fleshed out the conceptual design for audio alerts, we learned that we needed not just one, but at least four distinct concepts because the proximity of traders on the busy trading floor meant audio alerts from one user could interrupt a neighboring user if they were all using the same palette. The team had to create multiple palettes while ensuring they all fit the same brand ethos and values of the company.

17.5.5 Leverage Social and Psychological Aspects in the Design

Designers should be on the lookout throughout the process for opportunities to structure the design to take advantage of social and psychological factors. For example, if we are designing a fitness application, aspects in the work domain, such as motivation and feedback, can be structured to help users succeed emotionally by showing the number of steps they take each day and comparing it with friends and family.

17.6 EMOTIONAL IMPACT DESIGN PRODUCTION

The final design candidates for emotional impact are subjected to evaluation (see Part 5). Any ideas identified in the evaluation will kick off another round of refinements and modifications. Once the design is finalized, it is described in detail in the design production phase, where the objective is to define the design in enough detail so that it becomes a specification for software engineers to implement.

Fig. 17.7 provides the detailed design specification of a part of the visual design for the national parks application. Particulars, such as padding, sizes, and exact color specifications, are detailed for all visual elements used in the design.

Exercise 17.1 Conceptual Design for Emotional Response for Your Product or System

Think about your system and UX research data and envision a conceptual design in the emotional perspective (see [Section 5.6.1.2](#)). Create a mood board with ideas, themes, and inspirations to capture this vision. Try to communicate a vision of how the design elements will evoke emotional impact in users.

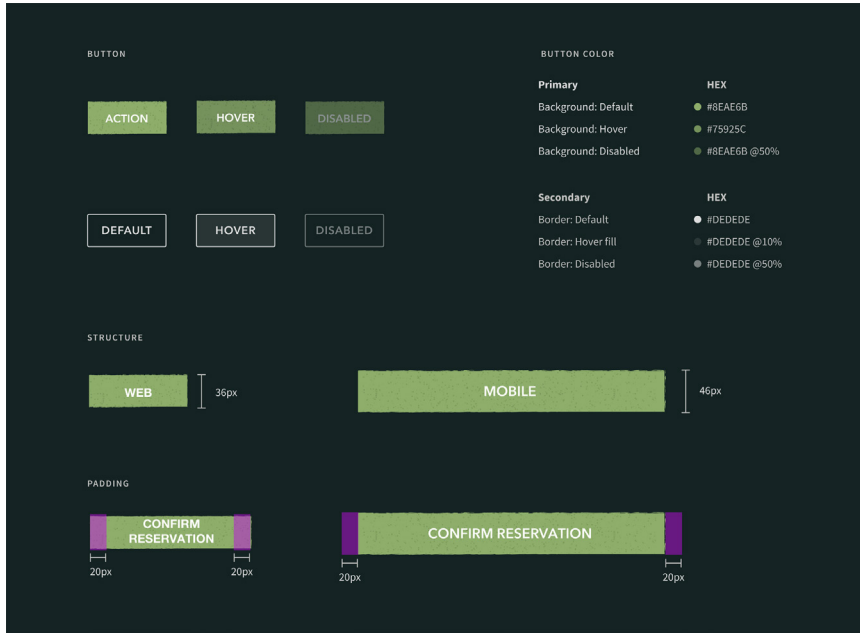


Fig. 17.7

Part of detailed visual design specification of the national parks application (from Christina Janczak, Product Design Manager, Arista Networks, Inc.).

17.7 SEQUE

In the previous two chapters, we covered designing for ecological and interaction needs. In this chapter, we discussed designing for emotional needs to wrap up Part 3. Next, we get into prototyping in Part 4.